

Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

Geek Sci-Fi

If you must present yourself to a congregation of geeks, you need to keep yourself abreast of stuff that will happen in the future, and the sci-fi greats that we have come to love so much.

Cylon (n.): The enemy from the series *Battlestar Galactica*. They're metal men, and naturally don't appreciate us fleshy men.

Usage: That helmet makes you look like a *Cylon*. All you need is LEDs flashing across your eyes.

Hari Seldon (n.): The creator of psychohistory and the two Foundations in Isaac Asimov's Foundation series.

Inordinately brilliant, and hero of the universe. Also long dead.

Usage: By *Seldon*, I will get you for this!

Skynet (n.): Rogue robot overlord that takes over the world in the *Terminator* series. Doesn't like humans, and takes special dislike towards John Connor. Also spelt e-v-i-l.

Usage: If we don't start building ethics into these robots soon, we'll be staring at a *Skynet* situation.

HAL9000 (n.): The AI that powers the Discovery in *2001: A Space Odessey*. Polite and friendly at most times, but tends to be a little...unbalanced. Sings moderately well.

Usage: I wish there was a *HAL9000* to drive this car. Then I wouldn't have to fear your reckless driving.

Replicant (n.): "Bio-engineered" robotic humans from *Blade Runner*. Look like regular people, only they are stronger and faster. Also (derog.) Skin-job.

Usage: "I just ran into a skin-job back there." "Hush now, be PC - they're replicants."

Wild Wild Web

The Phoenix Is A Twit

As you know, the Mars Phoenix rover powered down not too long ago, drawing a tear or two from its fans (apparently, people are that bored). What you didn't know was that the Phoenix apparently has enough juice (not to mention connectivity) to keep updating its Twitter feed. It is, in fact, speaking to us from beyond the grave. Some gems from the feed:

"The team has me on extreme "bed rest" to recharge power supply. There's cautious optimism about pulling out of this in a few days."

"Not everyone gets the chance to read their own

epitaph(s). So many great entries, I feel so loved :-)"

"01010100 01110010 01101001 01110101 01101101 01110000 01101000 <3"

If you want to follow the goings-on on Mars, or if you're one of those weepy fans, you can connect with your beloved rover at <http://twitter.com/MarsPhoenix>.



Web People Stupid

Has the Web made us a dumber generation? Or has the Web just brought out our inherent dumbness? The antics of News and Star don't seem to be encouraging either way. Maybe they're talking down to us dumb

users. Or maybe, they've become dumb users themselves. The picture above, to be precise:

They also add this helpful caption: "An egg." Of course, how silly of us not to recognise that. Now when we see anything of this ovoid nature headed our way, we'll be sure to remember that they will splatter, smell, and if collected, make a good omelette.

will find yourself stuck to your books more often.

2. Ye who use games to sharpen your minds, for there will be no sharpening.

3. Ye who think that as gamers, you are superior creatures. You are not.

Remember all those gaming studies we've talked about in these pages? The ones where we rejoice that gaming may, after all, be the key to well-developed brains, and that you should keep on gaming with our blessings? Well, we were wrong. Well, no. Correction. The researchers were wrong. We were misled, and are as outraged as you are.

According to a new study (likely by a sadistic researcher), gaming does not, in fact, have any positive effect on your cognitive skills. Walter Boot at the University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign made non-gamers spend over 20 hours with three different video games, and found that they showed no improvement in their memory or their ability to multitask, which goes

against all we have believed in so far — namely, that gamers have better-developed brains than non-gamers.

It isn't all bad news, however. Boot does admit that a few hours of action games improves concentration, so if you're having trouble paying attention, some hacking and slashing and blowing up might actually help. And to explain why the other studies said what they said, he flatters us — "Perhaps individuals with superior abilities are more likely to choose video gaming as an activity in the first place."

MULTI-BAND CELL PHONES

Strange, Beautiful Music

There's nothing more annoying than being in the vicinity of an air guitarist. And there's nothing more fun than being that air guitarist. Well, now there is. If you've

got a cell phone with an accelerometer — and so many new ones do — you're set to take air guitar (and air drum, and air piano) to a new, crazy level. With a new program, your motion-sensitive cell phone will actually produce the sound of these musical instruments.

Want to bang out some beats? Or make your guitar gently weep? Or tickle the ivories? Your solution is called ZoozBeats, and has been developed by the mad scientists at the Georgia Institute of Technology. ZoozBeats "is a gesture-based mobile musical studio, simple enough for non-musicians to immediately become musically expressive, but rich enough for experienced musicians to push the envelope of mobile music creation," and it doesn't just need an accelerometer, even though that's the most popular way to detect motion. ZoozBeats can even use your phone's camera to detect sudden movements and play an appropriate sound.

When you play with ZoozBeats, the probability of you creating actual music is actually very, very low. While you play with it, you'll most likely create a cacophony unpleasant enough to drive your neighbours away — which may or may not be a good thing, now that we think of it. And you'll look pretty silly — get a preview of this silliness at <http://www.zoozmobile.com/beat/>.

MOB MENTALITY

The Hunters Cometh

Robots in the military aren't a new thing — they've been used to detect land mines, and more importantly, go where no man would want to go. But the trouble with these robots is that in using one robot, you also use up one human, which isn't ideal. The whole point of a robotic army is to remove humans as far as possible, so one human per robot is pretty

Fooling The Network Admins

There is literally, a war of sorts, waged here at *Digit* — between the system administration guys and us, from the editorial team. The rules laid out by them don't allow us to download, or even surf sites like [YouTube](#) or [Orkut.com](#). Besides, they have loads of other measures apparently designed to increase productivity.

Although we continuously come up with measures and counter-measures, status quo is maintained. We survive online with new proxies each

day, as and when the last one is cordoned off. However, Rossi, the usually innovative one, known for his foolproof ideas, set up a Hamachi network connection back to his home with a proxy server set up on his home PC. He uses this set up to surf the internet from office. Of course, there are much simpler ways of going around. The smarter, new recruit — Kumar, just walked in and typed in the url to the UK version of [YouTube](#) and watched those insane human tetris videos. There's always an easy way out Rossi!

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inefficient resource utilisation. What if one human could command a whole team of robots?

Let us call this Stipulation One. Stipulation One is that the US Department of Defence has put out a call for a "software / hardware suit that would enable a multi-robot team, together with a human operator, to search for and detect a non-cooperative human subject." Each robot is to weigh 100 kg, and will report to the human when there's a "difficult decision" to be made.

Stipulation Two is that last year, iRobot signed a deal with Taser International to mount stun guns on military robots. Finally, Stipulation Three is that when you bring robots, stun guns and "non-cooperative" human subjects together, no good can come of it.

Now, what conclusions can we draw from these stipulations? Firstly, that the US military is apparently quite interested in getting themselves robotic hunting packs. Secondly, that they don't mind giving these robots stun guns. To

extrapolate a bit, it's possible that they don't mind machine guns, either. Obviously, we are all doomed. The top brass of the US Military has clearly been replaced by Combine Advisors, for the product they aim to create exists already:



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Blog

WATCH

Featured here are snippets from some of the best bloggers who have registered at the Blog Watch section on thinkdigit.com.

If you wish to be featured too, head to www.thinkdigit.com/blogger.php and sign-up.

Firefox 3.1 To Have Private Mode

Of the two big browsing features of 2008, one seems to run counter to where developers are driving their browsers. The melding of the location bar to the search bar was expected in Firefox and Opera, thanks to beta versions. Chrome has it, too, calling it the Omnibar. What seems to have caught developers off-guard has been the clamor for a universal switch to stop the cache and browsing history from recording anything at all.

<http://techfat.blogspot.com/2008/09/firefox-31-to-have-private-mode.html>

Another guide to Quicksilver

Joe Dunn is doing a nice series of articles on Quicksilver. He's

covered triggers and scripts so far with more on the way.

One thing I disagree with, though, is the excessive use of the "do shell script" AppleScript. I like the "Run Command in Shell" action just fine. But if you want an icon, writing an Obj-C wrapper isn't too much work. Especially since you have this source code.

I've also got a bit more on Quicksilver coming up shortly.

<http://lipidity.com/apple/another-guide-to-quicksilver/>

Video

Our movie 'Mera Number Kab Aayega' is out under the banner 'SVNIT Talkies'. Though the venture started for some competition, it could not be completed by then. At last Late

Latif has successfully completed the video, this time for entertainment purpose only. Other jobless people who took the risk were Suhas,Ashwin, Nikhil and many more.... look at the credits. With creativity pouring in from all sides, but also keeping in mind our academic load, we are in the making of next version, 'Mera Number Aayega - [Fully Loaded]', casting still open for SVNITians only. Contact me/team personally or leave a comment here.Budding/'Budded' critics can try out something here at the comment section. I wont delete 'em. People in my network can download the video from my computer \\ram .

<http://zone404.blogspot.com/2008/04/video.html>

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Study: unhappy people watch more television

Space Station Astronauts to conserve water by drinking their own purified urine

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